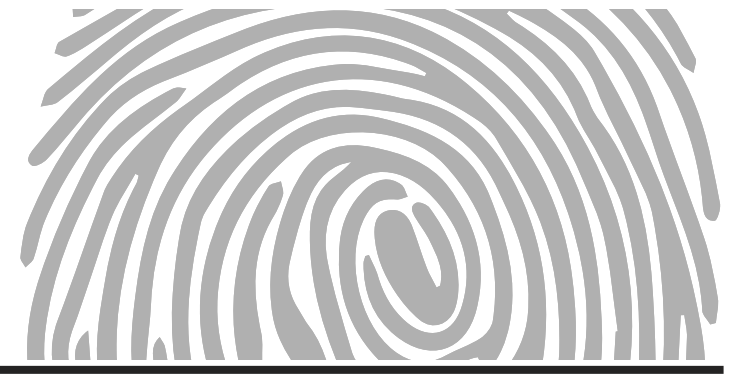


THE SLEUTH

BLACKMAN DETECTIVE SERVICES
(919) 821-0016

OCTOBER 2024



FROM THE CASE FILES: THE *SPOOKTACULAR* CASE OF THE MISSING GYM BAG

A man in his late 40's called in, frantically demanding that we find his missing gym bag. "I need my missing gym bag. I need it...NOW!"

"Okay, can you tell us where you lost it? What may have happened to it? Where was the last place you had seen it?"

"My ex-wife took it from me, just like she took everything from me. She's always been that way - a real taker. She's such a *witch*!"

"I'm sorry to hear that, sir. That sounds terrible. I've never been a fan of witches." *Or clowns, for that matter.* "For now, let's stick to the facts regarding the gym bag's possible whereabouts. Where was your gym bag when she took it from you? Did you see her physically take the gym bag? Did you report this act of theft to the police?"

"I apologize for the rant. Well, no, I don't feel comfortable disclosing the details. I don't want the police involved in this, you hear me?"

"Very loud and very clear, sir." I was undoubtedly bound to have tinnitus after this phone call was over. He continued to shout.

"You don't understand!" Well, that was certainly true. What could be so important in this gym bag? "I need this gym bag back! I need this gym bag back BY HALLOWEEN!"

"By Halloween, sir?"

"BY. HALLO. WEEN!"

"Understood. I'll see what I can do."

After a few follow-up phone calls were made, I drove over to the ex-wife's house, who thankfully agreed to meet with me and hand the gym bag over, given that I reassured her 100 times or so that he didn't want to get the police involved. I was seriously beginning to wonder what the heck was in this man's gym bag. Nobody needs a stick of Old Spice and some sweaty underwear so urgently by October 31...My imagination began wandering to macabre places. The thought of having to retrieve possible bloody body parts in a duffel bag just in time for Halloween might be above my pay grade.

A literal witch answered the door, accompanied by her new, second husband who was a literal clown. I just about choked on my own spit. *This is it. This how it all ends.*

"Here you go, my precious!" She cackled, handing over this most cursed gym bag. The clown stared blankly at me, neither frowning nor smiling - just staring. It didn't sit well with me.

"You have a good evening, ma'am and... clown."

Frightened, I quickly headed back to my car so that I could drive to a place that would have a restroom available. As I was speed-walking, I saw out of the corner of my eye a man wearing a king's crown and a royal-looking robe rip the gym bag out of my hands and run down the street! I couldn't believe it! It was my client!

Precious gym bag now in hand, he was laughing manically, shouting, "Yes, yes, it's mine - ALL mine!". Immediately, he unzipped the top of the bag and I braced myself for a horrific sight. Instead, I was surprised to see multiple pounds of candy: Reese's cups, Hershey bars, KitKats, Starburst, Twizzlers, Milky Way, Twix - it was all in the bag. He began throwing the pieces of candy up in the air, letting them rain down upon him. "I AM THE CANDY KING!"

Thankfully, there was a *sweet* ending to this case, after all.

LITTLE RED FLAGS: ARE YOU BEING *GHOSTED*?



It's important to recognize the signs of being ghosted so that you do not initiate unwanted contact, which when taken to extremes, could veer into the realm of harassment and stalking. Do not *haunt* your ghost! While it may be painful for someone you've invested care and time into to disappear, it is important to also respect that closure may not always be given externally by another person.

Here are some signs that you could be getting ghosted:

- You find yourself being left on "Read" with increasing frequency
- If the person does respond to your message(s), there is a substantial time delay when you hear back from them
- Communication feels very one-sided because they don't contribute much to keep the conversation going
- Their social media interactions with you greatly diminish (i.e. no longer "liking" your photos)

JUST THE (FUN) FACTS: LIFE AS A PI



Private investigators can occasionally find themselves in *scary* situations. For instance, a disgruntled Subject may try to get revenge, or an unruly Paramour (the Subject's *boo*) can attempt to get violent. While these types of incidents can make a day's work seem more like a *trick* rather than a *treat*, it is essential to work alongside a great team of other investigators who can give you a boost of moral support when you're feeling *ghoulish*. Teamwork is everything!

LEARN MORE AT WWW.BLACKMANPI.COM



CYBERSECURITY CORNER

NATIONAL PUBLIC DATA BREACH

Last month, National Public Data experienced a data breach that exposed social security numbers, as well as other personally identifiable information such as names, home addresses and email addresses, phone numbers, and more. This compromise conducted by bad actors has resulted in millions of people being affected. National Public Data is now facing a class-action lawsuit as a result, and the millions of individuals who have had their data compromised are now at risk of identity theft. If your information has been exposed, freezing your credit is essential to prevent further complications, such as fraud.

[SOURCE: HELLOGEORGETOWN.COM]

NOT TODAY, SCAMMERS!

SCAMS TO KNOW ABOUT: SKIMMING

Fall is finally in the swing of things, and you may be excited to grab some apple cider, have some family time at the local pumpkin patch, and take scenic drives across the Triangle and beyond. However, when filling up your car with gas at the pump, stay aware of the signs of skimming. Skimming occurs when a skimmer, which is an electronic device that stores credit card numbers and their PINS illegally, is placed within the credit card slot on the pump (or even in ATM machines). While it may often be difficult to discern whether or not your gas pump's credit card slot has been compromised by a skimmer, here are some potential things to consider: the closer the gas pump is to the store or in view of its employees, the less likely that pump will typically have a skimmer. Additionally, try to always opt for gas stations that give you the option to simply tap your card rather than inserting it.

[SOURCE: FBI.GOV]



CLIENT TESTIMONIAL

"Jamie and her team did a great job for us recently. Quick turnaround, great service."



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